

Talking Points for Inclusive Postsecondary Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability

Postsecondary education (PSE) programs provide opportunities for youth with intellectual disability to develop employment skills and become less dependent on family and public supports.

- In 2018–2019, 93% of students at model transition programs for students with intellectual disability (TPSIDs)* participated in paid employment or career development activities.¹
- 37% of students had a paid job while enrolled. Of those, 95% were working in competitive, integrated employment at or above minimum wage.¹

PSE programs are effective at helping students with intellectual disability find meaningful, competitive employment.

- 64% of students who completed TPSID programs in 2015-16 through 2017-18 had a paid job 1 year after exit.¹
- 52% of students were working in a paid job at exit or within the first 90 days after exiting.¹
- 75% of students either had a paid job (at exit or within 90 days), were participating in unpaid career development activities, had transferred to another postsecondary education program, or were doing a combination of these activities at exit.¹

PSE programs increase people's wages and help them achieve financial stability.

- Youth with intellectual disability who participated in postsecondary education and vocational rehabilitation services (VR) were more than twice as likely to exit with paid jobs, earned \$406 per month more on average, and required \$77 less per month in supplemental social security (SSI) benefits than their counterparts without postsecondary education.²

PSE programs offer a path to productivity and self-sufficiency for many people who've never had opportunities for employment before.

- 57% of employed TPSID graduates never had a paid job before enrolling in their program.¹

PSE programs promote inclusion of people with intellectual disability in society.

- PSE programs with residential campuses expose students with intellectual disability and individuals without intellectual disability to each other, helping to build personal and professional connections.

Possible state actions:

- Create a pilot program to provide PSE to students with intellectual disability.
- If a pilot program already exists, fund expansion to a consortium approach involving several colleges in the state.
- Open up state college grant and loan programs to people with intellectual disability, or create a specialized state scholarship program for students with intellectual disability.
- Explore use of lottery or other state funding as sources for scholarships.
- Provide support to institutions of higher education so that inclusive PSE programs can be created and sustained.
- Create a permanent commission or board to ensure the quality of PSE programs that support students with intellectual disability.

Sources

¹Grigal, M., Hart, D., Papay, C., Wu, X., Lazo, R., Smith, F., & Domin, D. (2021). Annual Report of the Cohort 2 TPSID Model

Demonstration Projects (Year 5, 2019–2020). Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

²Sannicandro, T. (2019). The effect of postsecondary education on employment, income, and SSI for people with intellectual disabilities. Think College Fast Facts, Issue No. 24. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

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